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Entrepreneurial self-efficacy in women's community-based tourism: a systematic review of success factors, barriers and theoretical gaps

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Abstract

Purpose – This paper systematically reviews the role of entrepreneurial self-efficacy (ESE) in shaping women's entrepreneurship within community-based tourism (CBT). It examines how ESE influences women's ability to initiate, sustain and grow tourism ventures while navigating structural and cultural constraints.

Design/methodology/approach – Following PRISMA guidelines, 53 peer-reviewed articles published between 2014 and 2026 were synthesised. The review identifies conceptual, theoretical and methodological trends and highlights emerging research priorities.

Findings – The review reveals four dominant themes: (1) ESE is the catalyst for women's entrepreneurial participation in tourism, (2) ESE contributes to CBT success factors through diversification, leadership and sustainability, (3) the enabling and constraining role of institutional support and (4) fragmented theoretical foundations in the ESE and CBT relationship.

Research limitations/implications – The review offers theoretical implications through an integrative contextual framework linking individual agency, institutional structure and community empowerment.

Practical implications – It also offers practical implications for policymakers and tourism authorities on capacity-building, institutional reform and inclusive governance to strengthen women's ESE in CBT.

Originality/value – This study systematically reviews ESE in CBT, proposing an integrative contextual framework that connects individual-level agency with institutional and socio-cultural dimensions of women's entrepreneurship in CBT. The review offers theoretical consolidation, practical implications for inclusive policy and a forward-looking agenda on digital and creative self-efficacy in tourism entrepreneurship.

Keywords Entrepreneurial self-efficacy (ESE), Women entrepreneurs, Community-based tourism (CBT), Empowerment, Systematic literature review

Paper type Literature review

1. Introduction

Community-based tourism (CBT) has increasingly been recognised as a strategic model for sustainable development, particularly in rural and marginalised regions. By positioning local communities at the centre of tourism activities, CBT promotes cultural preservation, environmental stewardship and equitable benefit-sharing (Abukhalifeh and Wondirad, 2019; Hlengwa and Maruta, 2020). Its diverse activities encompass village walks, agro-tourism, handicraft workshops, traditional food preparation and cultural performances, often requiring direct interaction between tourists and host families (Sharma *et al.*, 2024). In practice, CBT

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initiatives often involve locally managed homestays, community-guided tours and small-scale enterprises that rely heavily on the active participation and capabilities of residents (Asyraff *et al.*, 2024). Beyond economic outcomes, CBT strengthens community pride, intergenerational knowledge transfer and social cohesion.

Within this rural landscape, women entrepreneurs in CBT have become important agents of socio-economic transformation, managing homestays, leading eco-cultural initiatives, producing local crafts and organising tours to shape community identity and tourist experiences (Makandwa *et al.*, 2023). Their entrepreneurial engagement often encounters restricted access to financial resources, entrenched socio-cultural norms, inadequate institutional support and domestic responsibilities (Surangi, 2022), requiring women to rely on psychological resources that foster resilience and innovation.

Entrepreneurial self-efficacy (ESE), defined as an individual's belief in their capacity to perform entrepreneurial tasks effectively, has been identified as a central driver of entrepreneurial success in resource-constrained environments (Bandura, 1997; Malebana and Swanepoel, 2014). ESE has been widely acknowledged as an important determinant of entrepreneurial behaviour because it shapes how individuals identify opportunities, evaluate risks and persist in the face of obstacles. Within tourism and hospitality research, ESE has been consistently associated with entrepreneurial performance, innovation and business sustainability, particularly in small-scale and CBT enterprises (Madawala *et al.*, 2023; Najib *et al.*, 2020).

Studies have shown that higher levels of ESE enable women entrepreneurs to navigate market uncertainties better, engage with tourists effectively and sustain their ventures in resource-constrained CBT environments (Kakeesh, 2024; Khabbaz and Kuran, 2024). In tourism and hospitality contexts, ESE is reflected in women entrepreneurs' confidence in managing guest services, developing tourism products, engaging with visitors and adapting to fluctuating demand and operational uncertainties (Madawala *et al.*, 2023, 2025). In CBT contexts, where enterprises often face seasonal demand, limited infrastructure and fragile institutional support, women with high ESE are more likely to innovate, adapt and sustain their ventures (Makandwa *et al.*, 2023; Na-Allah and Ahmad, 2022).

Despite its relevance, research on ESE in women-led CBT enterprises remains fragmented. Existing studies have predominantly examined women's entrepreneurship in tourism through broader lenses, such as empowerment, participation and livelihood development, with limited emphasis on ESE as a central explanatory construct (Karatas-Ozkan *et al.*, 2024; Madawala *et al.*, 2023). ESE is often treated as a supporting variable rather than a primary construct, resulting in fragmented insights across psychological, institutional and empowerment perspectives (Mi *et al.*, 2024; Monje-Amor *et al.*, 2021), and theoretical perspectives differ from social cognitive theory (SCT) to institutional theory, producing inconsistent conceptualisations that manifest differently across regions such as Southeast Asia, Africa and Latin America (Molina-López *et al.*, 2021; Ojong *et al.*, 2021). This lack of coherence limits the systematic accumulation of knowledge. To date, no systematic literature review has explicitly examined how ESE has been conceptualised and studied among women entrepreneurs in CBT settings (Cabrera and Mauricio, 2017; Rosalina *et al.*, 2021; Swart *et al.*, 2024). As such, this study addresses that gap by systematically synthesising ESE-focused research within CBT.

Previous reviews in tourism and hospitality have effectively consolidated fragmented knowledge and outlined new research directions. However, a comprehensive review of ESE in tourism and hospitality has not yet been conducted. Past SLR papers on tourism and hospitality have addressed rural tourism definitions and challenges, smart tourism technologies and tourist satisfaction, women's empowerment in rural tourism and broader women's entrepreneurship in tourism (Rosalina *et al.*, 2021; Swart *et al.*, 2024; Vukovic *et al.*, 2023).

This study evaluates how ESE has been conceptualised, theorised and empirically examined within women-led CBT, exploring its antecedents, the theoretical and methodological approaches that underpin existing research and the gaps that inform future

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research directions. It further presents an Integrative Contextual Framework that connects ESE at the individual level with institutional and socio-cultural dimensions, contributing to theoretical clarity, practical insights for policy and development, and an agenda for inclusive and sustainable tourism entrepreneurship.

2. Methodology

This study adopts a systematic integrative review design, which permits the synthesis of empirical studies employing diverse methodologies alongside theoretical and review literature within a single review (Snyder, 2019; Torraco, 2005; Whittemore and Knafl, 2005). An integrative rather than a strictly aggregative design was selected because research positioned at the full intersection of ESE, women's entrepreneurship and CBT remains sparse; a review restricted to that intersection alone would yield too few studies to support meaningful synthesis, while excluding the adjacent bodies of evidence on which any theorisation of the construct must draw. The underlying synthesis logic is therefore configurative rather than aggregative (Gough *et al.*, 2012), oriented towards conceptual development rather than effect-size estimation, while reporting follows the PRISMA 2020 statement (Page *et al.*, 2021).

2.1 Ethical approval

As this study is a systematic literature review based entirely on previously published, publicly available research, it did not involve the recruitment of human or animal participants and no informed consent procedures were required. Institutional ethics clearance was nonetheless obtained for the review protocol from the Universiti Teknologi MARA Research Ethics Committee (Ref: 600-FHOTOUR (PJI 5/4)).

2.2 Sample and data collection

The review was conducted in stages designed to address the weaknesses of conventional narrative literature reviews. Following Pickering and Byrne's (2014) protocol, the review proceeded through five stages: defining the research question; formulating the search and eligibility criteria; searching and screening the literature; extracting and appraising the selected studies; and synthesising findings to identify gaps. This staged approach is well established in tourism and hospitality synthesis work for its comprehensiveness and consistency (Janjua *et al.*, 2021; Yang *et al.*, 2017). Searches were last executed in January 2026. The PRISMA flow for the review is presented in Figure 1.

Given the sparseness of research at the full three-way intersection noted above, the search was executed as three complementary strings rather than a single conjunctive query. String 1 (core) combined ("entrepreneurial self-efficacy" OR "ESE" OR "self-efficacy") AND ("women entrepreneur" OR "female entrepreneur" OR "women in tourism") AND ("community-based tourism" OR "CBT" OR "rural tourism" OR "homestay"). String 2 (contextual) combined ("community-based tourism" OR "CBT" OR "rural tourism" OR "homestay" OR "village tourism") AND ("entrepreneur" OR "enterprise" OR "livelihood" OR "empowerment"). String 3 (construct-level) combined ("entrepreneurial self-efficacy" OR "ESE") AND ("women" OR "gender" OR "female") AND ("intention" OR "performance" OR "persistence" OR "institutional support").

Searches were run across titles, abstracts and author keywords in Scopus, ScienceDirect and Taylor & Francis. Scopus served as the primary identification source, and Web of Science was not searched as an independent database. This decision reflects the substantial overlap between the two platforms: comparative analysis of their journal coverage indicates that Scopus indexes a considerably larger set of active peer-reviewed titles than Web of Science and subsumes the majority of Web of Science-indexed journals, with the difference concentrated in Scopus's broader inclusion of regional, non-English and social science outlets (Mongeon and Paul-Hus, 2016). Given that CBT scholarship is disproportionately published

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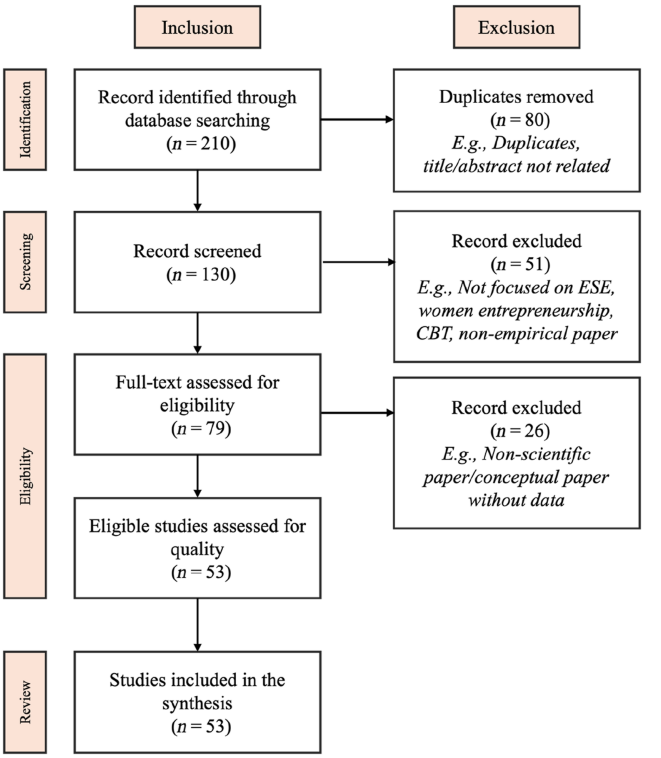


Figure 1. PRISMA flowchart for the systematic literature review on entrepreneurial self-efficacy among women in community-based tourism. Source: Adapted from Page *et al.* (2021)

in regionally situated and developing-country journals, Scopus offered the more inclusive single-platform coverage for the present review. ScienceDirect and Taylor & Francis were searched in addition to capture publisher-level content at full-text depth. Google Scholar was used to supplement rather than drive record identification; because it does not support the same field-restricted syntax, it was searched using free-text equivalents of the three strings, with screening limited to the first 200 results per string ranked by relevance. Record identification was further complemented by backward citation chasing from seminal ESE and CBT sources, which surfaced foundational works not retrievable through keyword search. Records from all sources were pooled before de-duplication.

Eligibility was assessed against tiered criteria corresponding to the three search streams, such that a record was retained if it satisfied the requirements of at least one stream. Core-stream eligibility required all three of an explicit ESE construct, a focus on women entrepreneurs and a community-based or rural tourism setting; only empirical studies were admitted at this level, since the core stream carries the review's primary evidentiary weight. Contextual-stream eligibility required a community-based or rural tourism setting combined with an entrepreneurship, enterprise or livelihood focus, without requiring ESE to be measured directly; this stream supplies the sectoral conditions under which self-efficacy operates. Construct-stream eligibility required an explicit ESE construct together with a gender dimension, without requiring a tourism setting; this stream supplies the conceptual and measurement foundations of ESE that the tourism literature has yet to consolidate. Conceptual papers, literature reviews and policy analyses were admitted only through the contextual and

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construct streams, where they provide theoretical scaffolding, and were excluded from the core stream. Across all three streams, records were excluded if they focused solely on male entrepreneurs, were not published in English, fell outside the 2014–2026 window or were unavailable in full text. Peer-reviewed journal articles, book chapters and conference papers were all eligible, reflecting the significant presence of edited-volume and conference outputs in CBT scholarship from developing-country contexts.

The initial search yielded 210 records. After removing duplicates and records whose titles or abstracts were unrelated to the review's scope (n = 80), 130 records were retained for screening. Title, abstract and full-text screening were conducted independently by two authors against the stream-specific criteria, with disagreements resolved through discussion; 77 records were excluded at this stage, yielding a final corpus of 53 studies for systematic synthesis (see Appendix). Because the synthesis is configurative rather than aggregative, retained studies were appraised for relevance and reporting adequacy rather than assessed for risk of bias against a quantitative instrument, on the basis that methodological heterogeneity across the three streams precludes a common appraisal metric (Gough *et al.*, 2012).

2.3 Data analysis

Bibliographic and study-characteristic data were extracted into a structured Microsoft Excel matrix. Full texts were then imported into NVivo 14. Initial codes were generated using the software's text-search and auto-coding functions to identify recurrent constructs across the corpus. These machine-generated codes served as an orienting device only and were subsequently reviewed, merged, renamed or discarded by the authors through iterative manual coding (Carvalho and Alves, 2023). Coding was conducted independently by two authors, with discrepancies resolved through discussion until consensus was reached, after which one author coded the remainder with periodic verification by the second. Given the configurative aim of the synthesis, agreement was pursued through dialogic consensus rather than reported as a numerical inter-coder coefficient (Gough *et al.*, 2012).

3. Results

The selected articles on CBT primarily focus on homestays and village tourism (Balasingam, 2022; Luekveerawattana, 2024; Priatmoko *et al.*, 2021), agro-tourism and food-related enterprises (Amir *et al.*, 2017; Najib *et al.*, 2020) and cultural and creative tourism initiatives involving handicrafts, heritage and artistic practices that sustain community livelihoods (Khalid *et al.*, 2025; Martini *et al.*, 2020; Rosca *et al.*, 2020). Other works focused on women entrepreneurs in rural or resource-constrained environments (Agumadu *et al.*, 2020; Na-Allah and Ahmad, 2022; Durrah *et al.*, 2024; Noor and Isa, 2020; Shahzad *et al.*, 2021; Xiaoning *et al.*, 2026; Filimonau *et al.*, 2024).

Several studies have also emphasised institutional and psychological perspectives, applying SCT and institutional theory to examine the determinants of ESE in CBT contexts (Maheshwari and Kha, 2022; Malebana and Swanepoel, 2014; Nikmah *et al.*, 2023; Shastri *et al.*, 2019).

3.1 Key findings and thematic synthesis

The analysis highlights four dominant themes: (1) ESE is the catalyst for women's entrepreneurial participation in tourism, (2) ESE contributes to CBT success factors through diversification, leadership and sustainability, (3) the enabling and constraining role of institutional support and (4) fragmented theoretical foundations in the ESE and CBT relationship. Table 1 summarises the thematic analysis focus areas, key contradictions and gaps identified across the reviewed literature.

3.1.1 ESE among women in tourism. A consistent finding across the reviewed studies is the centrality of ESE in shaping women's entrepreneurial participation in CBT. Defined as an

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Table 1. Thematic analysis matrix

Theme	Focus areas	Key contradictions/Limitations	Research gaps
1. ESE among women in tourism	• Women's confidence in homestays, handicrafts, agro-tourism, food tourism, cultural performance. • Socially embedded self-efficacy (family, peer networks, community validation). • Regional variations (Africa – collective action; Southeast Asia – heritage-based)	• High self-efficacy does not always translate into entrepreneurial success due to systemic barriers (gender norms, lack of finance, bureaucracy) • Overreliance on informal mentoring vs structured training	• Limited longitudinal studies on how ESE evolves across entrepreneurial life stages • Need for comparative studies across cultural contexts to capture diverse pathways of ESE development
2. ESE and CBT success factors	• Role of ESE in diversification (culinary, agro-tourism, handicrafts) • Leadership and mentoring roles in cooperatives • Operational sustainability (record-keeping, service quality, market positioning)	• Women innovate and lead but remain constrained by poor infrastructure, digital gaps and seasonal demand • Strong ESE often limited to micro-enterprises, lacking scalability	• Further exploration on how ESE can interact with digital platforms, value chain integration and destination competitiveness • Need for multi-level analysis (individual–community–destination)
3. Role of institutional support	• Formal institutions: microfinance, training programs, policy incentives • Informal institutions: family support, kinship networks, cooperatives • Governance and policy inconsistencies shaping CBT participation	• Implementation gaps: policy design vs grassroots realities • Informal institutions empower but also reinforce gendered expectations (dual burden of domestic + entrepreneurial roles) • Gatekeeping by male-dominated networks limiting women's access to training/credit	• Need for equity-focused evaluation of institutional support (accessibility, inclusivity, outcomes) • Comparative studies on policy-to-practice gaps in different governance systems
4. Theoretical approaches and gaps	• Dominance of Social Cognitive Theory (SCT) to explain ESE • Emerging use of Institutional Theory • Limited application of empowerment/motivational frameworks	• Theoretical fragmentation: many atheoretical or descriptive works • SCT and institutional theory remain siloed and rarely integrated • Empowerment invoked but weakly theorised	• Integration of SCT and Institutional Theory for multi-level analysis (agency + structure) • Deeper theorisation of empowerment in relation to ESE • Development of interdisciplinary frameworks linking cognitive, social and structural dimensions

Source(s): Authors' own work

individual's belief in their ability to perform entrepreneurial tasks (Bandura, 1999), ESE strongly influenced women's willingness to initiate and sustain ventures such as homestays, handicraft businesses, food enterprises, agro-tourism and cultural performances (Amir *et al.*, 2017; Balasingam, 2022; Luekveerawattana, 2024; Najib *et al.*, 2020). Women with high self-

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efficacy exhibited greater confidence in risk-taking, opportunity recognition and strategic planning, allowing them to persist in contexts where institutional environments were fragile or inconsistent (Ariffin *et al.*, 2021; Ferreira-Neto *et al.*, 2023; Hamdani *et al.*, 2023; Makandwa *et al.*, 2023; Na-Allah and Ahmad, 2022).

However, findings across regions highlight that ESE is not merely an individual psychological trait, but a socially embedded construct. Many women developed entrepreneurial confidence through peer mentorship, community validation and family support, rather than formal entrepreneurial training (Alzyoud *et al.*, 2023; Durrah *et al.*, 2024; Neneh, 2022). This challenges Western-centric entrepreneurship models that privilege structured training and education as the primary sources of self-efficacy, highlighting the importance of localised, informal learning pathways in rural, resource-constrained tourism contexts. For instance, in Southern Africa, women's ESE was reinforced through informal mentoring networks within CBT cooperatives (Makandwa *et al.*, 2023; Moswete and Lacey, 2015; Nziku and Henry, 2021).

Moreover, findings suggest regional variation in the manifestation of ESE. In Sub-Saharan Africa, women's ESE was often linked to collective action and resource pooling in CBT ventures (Agumadu *et al.*, 2020; Makandwa *et al.*, 2023; Ngoasong and Kimbu, 2019), whereas in Southeast Asia, self-efficacy was closely tied to cultural capital and heritage-based entrepreneurship (Luekveerawattana, 2024; Najib *et al.*, 2020; Priatmoko *et al.*, 2021). These contextual differences highlight that ESE is not a uniform construct but is shaped by cultural norms, institutional arrangements and market conditions.

Despite its empowering potential, several studies reveal that ESE alone is insufficient to overcome systemic barriers. Women with strong confidence still struggled when confronted with entrenched gender norms, lack of access to financial capital and bureaucratic obstacles (Noor and Isa, 2020; Shahzad *et al.*, 2021; Surangi, 2022). This reflects a contradiction in the literature; while ESE consistently enables women to take initiative and innovate, its translation into sustained success is heavily mediated by structural and institutional conditions.

Another critical insight is that ESE is dynamic and evolves. Several studies documented how women's confidence grew incrementally through experiential success, role modelling and visible achievements, with initial small-scale successes in handicrafts or homestays fostering the confidence to diversify into more complex ventures such as tour operations or cooperative leadership (Makandwa *et al.*, 2023; Martini *et al.*, 2020; Priatmoko *et al.*, 2021; Rosca *et al.*, 2020). Yet most studies were cross-sectional, limiting insight into how ESE develops longitudinally across life stages (Abbasianchavari and Moritz, 2021; Cabrera and Mauricio, 2017; Garaika *et al.*, 2019), pointing to a methodological gap that longitudinal and process-oriented research is needed to address.

3.1.2 ESE and CBT success factors. The literature confirms that ESE plays a pivotal role in shaping the critical success factors of CBT, particularly product diversification, community leadership and operational sustainability (Abukhalifeh and Wondirad, 2019). Women with strong self-efficacy often acted as catalysts of innovation by expanding tourism portfolios beyond traditional homestays. They introduced culinary workshops, agro-tourism activities, handicraft demonstrations and heritage storytelling, which not only diversified income streams but also enriched the authenticity of tourist experiences (Amir *et al.*, 2017; Na-Allah and Ahmad, 2022; Martini *et al.*, 2020; Priatmoko *et al.*, 2021; Rosca *et al.*, 2020).

ESE was also strongly linked to community leadership and empowerment. Women entrepreneurs with high levels of self-efficacy were more likely to assume leadership roles within cooperatives, influence village decision-making and mentor new entrepreneurs (Balasingam, 2022; Maheshwari and Kha, 2022; Malek and Costa, 2015), manage their own ventures and mobilise collective participation (Ariffin *et al.*, 2021; Noreña-Chavez and Guevara, 2020). Another success factor strengthened by ESE is operational sustainability. Women with higher entrepreneurial confidence adopted structured business practices such as financial record-keeping, proactive booking management and service quality monitoring (Altinay *et al.*, 2026; Luekveerawattana, 2024; Nziku and Henry, 2021). These operational

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improvements enhanced the credibility of CBT enterprises, contributing to repeat visits, positive word of mouth and a stronger destination reputation. Despite these positive outcomes, the findings also highlight critical contradictions.

Women's creativity, resilience and leadership were often constrained by structural weaknesses, such as poor infrastructure, limited access to broader tourism markets and dependency on seasonal demand (Abbasianchavari and Moritz, 2021). Women with strong self-efficacy demonstrated innovation and persistence. Still, their ventures frequently remained at a micro-enterprise level, unable to scale due to a lack of digital connectivity, logistics or institutional support (Agumadu *et al.*, 2020; Makandwa *et al.*, 2023; Ngoasong and Kimbu, 2019; Shahab *et al.*, 2019). Similarly, high-ESE women diversified CBT offerings in Southeast Asia, yet inadequate policy support restricted integration with mainstream tourism value chains (Hamdani *et al.*, 2023; Klongthong *et al.*, 2020). These contradictions confirm that ESE is necessary but insufficient for CBT success. Translating self-belief into long-term viability requires enabling ecosystems, including policy frameworks, digital infrastructure, market access and inclusive financial systems, without which women's entrepreneurial journeys risk remaining constrained to subsistence-level survival.

Taken together, these findings point to a critical interaction effect between psychological and institutional factors. Where both ESE and institutional support are present, women entrepreneurs experience reinforcing conditions that enable diversification, scaling and community leadership (Na-Allah and Ahmad, 2022; Nikmah *et al.*, 2023); where one or both are absent, capability and support fail to translate into sustained outcomes (Hamdani *et al.*, 2023).

3.1.3 Role of institutional support. In contexts where formal institutional mechanisms were supportive, women's self-efficacy translated more effectively into entrepreneurial growth. Microfinance schemes, targeted training programs and policy incentives were shown to amplify entrepreneurial confidence and widen opportunity horizons (Al Issa *et al.*, 2019; Na-Allah and Ahmad, 2022; Nikmah *et al.*, 2023). For example, studies in Nigeria and Indonesia highlighted how access to microcredit and government-backed tourism programs allowed women to diversify their CBT ventures, strengthen service delivery and integrate into wider tourism value chains (Ali *et al.*, 2024; Bagus *et al.*, 2019).

Similarly, structured training programs improved both technical capacity and psychological readiness, reinforcing women's belief in their entrepreneurial abilities (Rao *et al.*, 2022). However, the review also revealed significant weaknesses. Comparative analyses point to fragmented governance and policy ambiguities that erode community trust and undermine the sustainability of CBT initiatives, even where entrepreneurial motivation is high (Giampiccoli *et al.*, 2020). Likewise, in several Sub-Saharan contexts, policies that existed on paper failed to reach women at the grassroots level due to bureaucratic inefficiencies and limited institutional outreach (Makandwa *et al.*, 2023; Nziku and Henry, 2021). These examples illustrate a persistent implementation gap between policy design and practice.

In the absence of strong formal structures, informal institutions, particularly family support, kinship networks and community trust, emerged as crucial substitutes. Durrah *et al.* (2024) reported that family encouragement and local community recognition in Oman significantly motivated rural women to pursue tourism ventures, compensating for weak institutional mechanisms. In Southern Africa, peer mentoring within women's cooperatives also built ESE and strengthened CBT participation (Makandwa *et al.*, 2023; Moswete and Lacey, 2015). Yet, the reliance on informal institutions brought contradictions. Family and community networks nurtured self-efficacy and reinforced gendered expectations, with women expected to manage domestic roles and entrepreneurial responsibilities simultaneously (Msimango-Galawe and Mazonde, 2024; Surangi, 2022). This dual burden limited the scalability of women's ventures, often confining them to micro-enterprises rather than growth-oriented enterprises. Thus, informal institutions function as double-edged swords: while they provide immediate psychological and material support, they also reinforce structural inequalities.

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A critical insight from the reviewed literature is that institutional support often fails to align with grassroots realities. While training programs, credit facilities and entrepreneurship schemes may formally exist, women frequently reported difficulties accessing them due to bureaucratic red tape, lack of information dissemination and entrenched cultural gatekeeping (Nziku and Henry, 2021; Pelegrini and Moraes, 2022; Shastri *et al.*, 2019). In South Asia and Sub-Saharan Africa, access was often mediated by male-dominated networks where husbands, village leaders or local elites acted as gatekeepers filtering women's opportunities to participate in training or secure loans (Agumadu *et al.*, 2020; Garaika *et al.*, 2019; Shahab *et al.*, 2019; Shastri *et al.*, 2019). Such mediation reinforced existing power hierarchies and left many women dependent on intermediaries rather than being able to engage autonomously. This gap between policy design and lived experience underscores that institutional support cannot be measured solely by its existence on paper. It must also be evaluated in terms of practical accessibility, inclusivity and equity of outcomes. Without attention to these dimensions, even well-intentioned initiatives risk perpetuating structural inequalities instead of alleviating them. Taken together, these findings indicate that formal and informal institutions function as structural scaffolding within which women's ESE is either cultivated or suppressed, and that neither a purely psychological nor a purely structural account alone explains the heterogeneity of outcomes observed across contexts (Al Issa *et al.*, 2019; Durrah *et al.*, 2024; Moswete and Lacey, 2015; Nikmah *et al.*, 2023).

3.1.4 Theoretical approaches and gaps. The fourth theme concerns the theoretical foundations on which the reviewed studies rest, which are unevenly applied. SCT (Bandura, 1997, 1999) is the dominant framework, applied in the largest share of the corpus to frame ESE as a driver of entrepreneurial intention, persistence and performance shaped through observation, experiential mastery, peer support and community validation (Abbasianchavari and Moritz, 2021; Bastian *et al.*, 2018; Makandwa *et al.*, 2023; Malebana and Swanepoel, 2014; Neneh, 2022). This framing is particularly evident in studies set in Southeast Asia and Sub-Saharan Africa, where confidence was reported as cultivated through informal learning rather than formalised education (Fan *et al.*, 2023; Iraola-Arroyo *et al.*, 2020).

A smaller set of studies draws on Institutional Theory to examine how formal rules, policies and informal cultural norms shape women's entrepreneurial opportunities (Ngoasong and Kimbu, 2019; Nikmah *et al.*, 2023; Nziku and Henry, 2021), demonstrating how institutional structures facilitate or constrain the translation of self-efficacy into entrepreneurial outcomes. Empowerment and motivational frameworks appear in a further group of studies (Cabrera and Mauricio, 2017; Pelegrini and Moraes, 2022; Rosca *et al.*, 2020), but their application is inconsistent, with empowerment more often invoked as an assumed outcome of participation than operationalised as a theorised construct interacting with self-efficacy (Yousafzai and Aljanova, 2025).

Against this, a considerable proportion of the reviewed studies are atheoretical or only weakly grounded, reporting empirical findings without a guiding conceptual framework (Garaika *et al.*, 2019; Maldonado-Erazo *et al.*, 2020; Msimango-Galawe and Mazonde, 2024; Narkunienė and Ulbinaitė, 2018). Two gaps follow. First, the absence of an explicit theoretical anchor in a substantial share of the corpus limits both the transferability of findings across contexts and the cumulative development of theory. Second, and more consequentially, few studies integrate SCT's focus on individual agency with institutional theory's emphasis on structural conditions; the two remain largely siloed, and empowerment frameworks remain underdeveloped as a bridge between them. Understanding women's entrepreneurship in CBT requires approaches that connect micro-level agency with macro-level institutional realities, yet most studies continue to treat these dimensions separately.

4. Discussion and conclusion

4.1 Conclusion

This review systematically examined how ESE has been studied in women's entrepreneurship in CBT. The findings demonstrate that ESE is both an individual psychological resource and a

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socially embedded construct shaped through peer networks, experiential learning and community recognition, enabling women to initiate and sustain CBT ventures, diversify products and assume leadership roles. However, translating self-efficacy into long-term success is conditional on enabling institutional environments. Gender norms, access to finance, training, digital infrastructure and inclusive governance all moderate how confidence converts into innovation and sustainability. Beyond these empirical findings, this review makes a theoretical contribution by proposing an integrative contextual framework of ESE in CBT. It positions its findings in relation to feminist tourism entrepreneurship perspectives, arguing that ESE is inherently gendered and that its conversion into livelihood outcomes depends on the multi-capital asset environment within which women operate. Finally, the review underscores that fostering women's entrepreneurship in CBT requires more than skills training. Programmes must simultaneously build self-efficacy and dismantle institutional barriers through inclusive policies, accessible financing schemes and recognition of informal knowledge systems. Supporting women in CBT is an equity issue and a strategic investment in sustainable tourism development, cultural heritage preservation and rural economic resilience.

4.2 Theoretical implications

Drawing on these synthesised findings, this review proposes an integrative contextual framework of ESE in CBT (Figure 2), conceptualising women's CBT entrepreneurship as operating across three interacting levels: the individual, the institutional and the community.

To address the theoretical fragmentation identified, this review proposes an integrative contextual framework (Figure 2) that explicitly bridges SCT's focus on individual agency with institutional theory's emphasis on structural conditions, while incorporating empowerment as a rigorously theorised outcome rather than an assumed by-product of participation. The framework operationalises this integration through three explicit pathways. The agency to confidence pathway draws on SCT to explain how women's self-efficacy is cultivated through experiential learning, role modelling and community validation, positioning ESE as a dynamic, socially embedded construct rather than a fixed individual trait (Bandura, 1997;

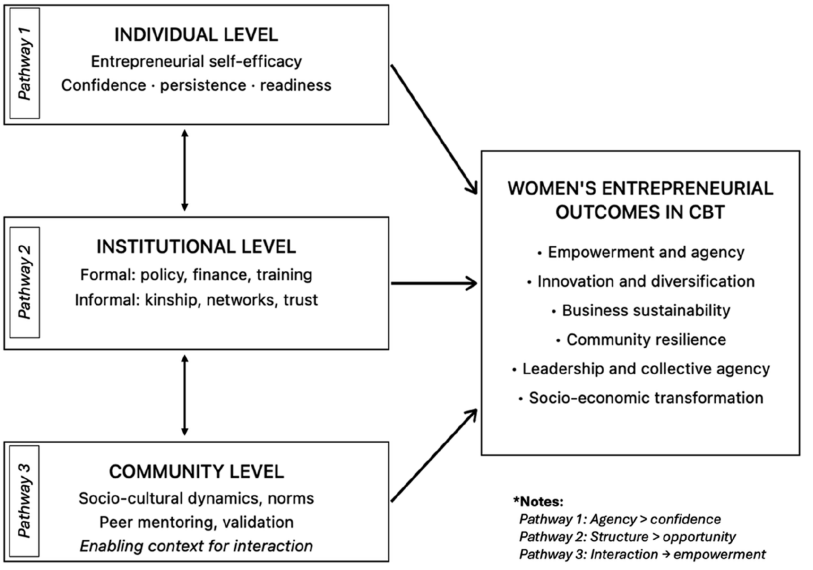


Figure 2. Integrative contextual framework of entrepreneurial self-efficacy in community-based tourism. Source: Authors' own work

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Makandwa *et al.*, 2023). The structure to opportunity pathway draws on institutional theory to illustrate how formal and informal institutional conditions, including governance frameworks, cultural norms and resource accessibility, mediate the translation of individual self-belief into observable entrepreneurial outcomes (Nikmah *et al.*, 2023; Nziku and Henry, 2021). The Interaction to Empowerment pathway captures the compounding effect that emerges when individual agency and enabling structural conditions align, producing not only entrepreneurial success for individual women but broader community empowerment and socio-economic transformation (Khalid *et al.*, 2025; Yousafzai and Aljanova, 2025). Integrating these three pathways offers a more theoretically complete account of women's entrepreneurship in CBT than single-theory approaches permit.

The review underscores that the impact of ESE is contingent on institutional conditions. Where supportive structures, such as microfinance, digital infrastructure and policy frameworks, were accessible, women's confidence translated into business growth and wider value chain participation (Al Issa *et al.*, 2019; Na-Allah and Ahmad, 2022; Nikmah *et al.*, 2023). Conversely, in contexts with weak institutional support, ESE often remained latent. This echoes propositions from Institutional Theory, which stress that agency is shaped by broader systems, rules and norms (Nikmah *et al.*, 2023; Nziku and Henry, 2021; Ngoasong and Kimbu, 2019). Informal institutions such as family, kinship and peer networks often served as substitutes for weak formal structures (Durrah *et al.*, 2024; Moswete and Lacey, 2015). While these provided immediate psychological and material support, they simultaneously reinforced gendered expectations, confining women to micro-enterprises and dual domestic–entrepreneurial roles (Msimango-Galawe and Mazonde, 2024; Surangi, 2022). This duality highlights the institutional paradox. Support mechanisms can empower but also constrain, depending on accessibility and inclusivity.

The findings of this review also invite critical positioning in relation to two broader theoretical traditions, feminist tourism entrepreneurship perspectives and sustainable livelihoods approaches. Feminist tourism entrepreneurship scholarship argues that women's participation in tourism cannot be adequately understood through gender-neutral frameworks, but requires examination through gendered power relations, patriarchal structures and the politics of recognition (Karatas-Ozkan *et al.*, 2024; Moswete and Lacey, 2015). From this perspective, the structural barriers documented in this review, including restricted access to finance, male-dominated institutional gatekeeping and the dual burden of domestic and entrepreneurial responsibilities, are systemic expressions of gender inequality rather than incidental constraints (Surangi, 2022).

This review extends these perspectives by demonstrating that ESE itself is gendered, as its development, expression and outcomes are shaped by patriarchal norms that differentially distribute recognition, opportunity and institutional access. Where feminist solidarity and collective agency were present, as in CBT cooperatives in Southern Africa and Kyrgyzstan, women's ESE functioned not merely as an individual asset but as a politically transformative force challenging entrenched inequalities in tourism governance (Makandwa *et al.*, 2023; Yousafzai and Aljanova, 2025). The Sustainable Livelihoods Approach offers a complementary lens, conceptualising ESE as a form of human capital that enhances women's capacity to mobilise social, financial, cultural and natural capital into sustainable livelihood outcomes (Khalid *et al.*, 2025), reinforcing the Integrative Contextual Framework proposed in this review.

Some studies also referenced empowerment and motivational frameworks (Cabrera and Mauricio, 2017; Pelegrini and Moraes, 2022; Rosca *et al.*, 2020), but their application was inconsistent, often invoking empowerment as an outcome of women's participation in CBT rather than a rigorously theorised construct interacting with self-efficacy (Yousafzai and Aljanova, 2025). Motivational perspectives were similarly under-operationalised, leaving these frameworks scattered and unable to contribute meaningfully to theory consolidation. Future research can strengthen this integration by positioning empowerment as an outcome emerging from the interaction between individual self-efficacy and enabling institutional conditions. This leaves the field's theoretical picture fragmented. SCT explains self-belief and agency, Institutional Theory clarifies structural barriers, but the two remain siloed and empowerment frameworks are underdeveloped, underscoring the need for the integrated model this review proposes.

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4.3 Practical implications

Beyond individual confidence, the reviewed literature shows that ESE contributes directly to CBT venture success through product diversification, community leadership and operational sustainability, as detailed in the Results section above. Yet strong self-efficacy does not eliminate structural barriers. Inadequate infrastructure, limited digital connectivity and seasonal demand continue to constrain women's ventures (Agumadu *et al.*, 2020; Hamdani *et al.*, 2023). ESE therefore remains necessary but insufficient for sustainable CBT success, pointing to the need for a shift from individual-centric entrepreneurship models towards ecosystem-based approaches that integrate psychological, institutional and community-level dynamics. The following practical implications for policymakers, tourism authorities and community stakeholders follow directly from this shift. The findings of this review provide several practical implications for policymakers, tourism authorities and community stakeholders, presented in order of priority, from individual-level capacity building, through institutional reform, to systemic governance transformation.

First, enhancing women's ESE requires targeted capacity-building initiatives that go beyond basic training. Structured programmes should incorporate mentorship, experiential learning and peer-to-peer knowledge exchange to strengthen women's confidence, problem-solving abilities and entrepreneurial decision-making in real tourism contexts (Kakeesh, 2024; Khabbaz and Kuran, 2024; Na-Allah and Ahmad, 2022; Nikmah *et al.*, 2023). In practice, this means structured mentorship cycles pairing emerging entrepreneurs with experienced CBT practitioners, delivered in accessible, vernacular-language community venues and integrating practical skills in product development, digital marketing and financial record-keeping.

Second, strengthening institutional support mechanisms is critical to ensuring that women entrepreneurs can effectively translate self-efficacy into sustainable business performance. Policymakers should prioritise improving access to financial resources, simplifying bureaucratic procedures and enhancing the accessibility of entrepreneurship support programmes at the grassroots level (Ali *et al.*, 2024; Durrah *et al.*, 2024; Makandwa *et al.*, 2023). In addition, integrating digital tools and infrastructure into CBT development strategies can further support women in expanding market reach and improving operational efficiency (Fan *et al.*, 2023; Nikmah *et al.*, 2023). Concretely, this requires gender-responsive micro-loan schemes with simplified eligibility criteria, dedicated CBT extension officers to provide on-the-ground guidance and subsidised access to online booking and payment platforms, without which individual-level capacity-building risks being undermined by persistent institutional barriers.

Third, the findings highlight the significant role of informal support systems, including family networks, peer mentoring and community cooperation, in reinforcing women's entrepreneurial confidence and participation (Durrah *et al.*, 2024; Moswete and Lacey, 2015). While these informal mechanisms are valuable, policymakers should ensure that they are complemented by formal institutional support to prevent the reinforcement of existing gender inequalities and to enable women to scale their ventures beyond subsistence levels (Shahzad *et al.*, 2021). In practice, this means formalising peer mentoring within officially recognised community development programmes and delivering gender-sensitisation programmes for male community members to reduce gatekeeping and redistribute domestic responsibilities.

Moreover, tourism authorities should promote inclusive and community-driven governance models that actively position women as leaders and decision-makers in CBT initiatives. Empowering women in leadership roles not only enhances individual entrepreneurial outcomes but also strengthens collective community resilience, social cohesion and long-term sustainability of tourism development (Balasingam, 2022; Priatmoko *et al.*, 2021; Xiaoning *et al.*, 2026). Specific pathways include mandating minimum gender-representation thresholds in local tourism governance bodies, establishing women's leadership development tracks within tourism authorities, and creating formal recognition mechanisms that validate women's informal knowledge contributions to CBT heritage and product development.

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The findings emphasise that strengthening ESE alone is insufficient without supportive institutional, social and policy environments. A coordinated approach that integrates individual capacity-building with structural support systems is essential to unlocking the full potential of women's entrepreneurship in CBT and achieving inclusive and sustainable tourism development (Khalid *et al.*, 2025; Madawala *et al.*, 2025; Yousafzai and Aljanova, 2025).

4.4 Limitations and future research

This review is limited by its reliance on published peer-reviewed studies, which may introduce publication bias and exclude grassroots practices documented in grey literature. The geographic distribution of existing studies is also uneven, concentrating on Southeast Asia and Sub-Saharan Africa, with Latin America, Central Asia, the Middle East and small island states remaining underexplored. Methodologically, the dominance of cross-sectional survey designs restricts insight into how ESE evolves dynamically across entrepreneurial life cycles, as few qualitative or longitudinal studies explored dynamic, relational confidence-building processes over time. The search was conducted across Scopus, ScienceDirect, Taylor & Francis and Google Scholar. However, Emerald Insight and Web of Science content was partially captured through Scopus indexing; their exclusion as independent sources is acknowledged as a limitation.

Table 2 outlines priority directions for future research on ESE in CBT.

Future research should also adopt integrated models that connect agency, structure and empowerment, capturing how psychological readiness interacts with systemic enablers and barriers. It should empirically test and refine the integrative contextual framework proposed in

Table 2. Future research directions on ESE in CBT

Future research area	Key issues identified	Recommended directions
Theoretical integration	Over-reliance on SCT; weak application of institutional/empowerment theories; fragmented perspectives (agency vs structure)	Develop integrated frameworks linking SCT, institutional theory and empowerment to capture how psychological readiness interacts with systemic barriers/enablers
Geographic expansion	Strong bias towards Southeast Asia and Sub-Saharan Africa; limited studies in Latin America, Central Asia, the Middle East and small island states	Broaden geographic coverage to test generalisability of ESE across diverse cultural and institutional contexts
Demographic diversity	Focus mainly on adult women; younger and older generations are overlooked	Explore youth (digital fluency + ESE), elderly (heritage knowledge + ESE) and intergenerational transfer of confidence and cultural capital
Emerging constructs	Limited attention to digital and creative self-efficacy despite tourism digitalisation and innovation needs	Examine how digital self-efficacy (online marketing, bookings, platforms) and creative self-efficacy (culinary, heritage, eco-guiding) intersect with entrepreneurial confidence
Methodological innovation	Dominance of cross-sectional surveys; few longitudinal or participatory designs	Apply longitudinal, mixed-method and participatory action research to trace evolving ESE, link statistics with lived experiences and co-produce knowledge with communities
Policy and practice relevance	Skills training alone is insufficient; institutional barriers remain	Future research should evaluate inclusive policies, financing schemes and recognition of informal knowledge systems as enablers of ESE in CBT

Source(s): Authors' own work

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this review across diverse institutional contexts and geographic settings. Most studies focus on adult women, overlooking the experiences of youth and elderly entrepreneurs and intergenerational knowledge transfer, despite youth bringing digital fluency and older women holding indigenous knowledge as cultural capital. Future research should examine how ESE manifests differently across life stages and how confidence is transmitted intergenerationally.

The digitalisation of tourism highlights an urgent need to examine digital self-efficacy. With marketing, booking and customer engagement increasingly mediated online, digital confidence is an essential subset of ESE. Yet, many rural women remain digitally marginalised due to poor infrastructure, limited exposure and inadequate education. Similarly, creative self-efficacy is underexplored. Women with high ESE diversify CBT by introducing culinary workshops, heritage storytelling and eco-guiding, but few studies explicitly analyse how entrepreneurial and creative confidence intersect. Future research should investigate how digital and creative self-efficacy interact with entrepreneurial confidence to shape CBT innovation, competitiveness and sustainability.

Methodologically, the field is dominated by cross-sectional surveys and descriptive case studies, which cannot capture the evolving nature of self-efficacy across entrepreneurial life cycles. Longitudinal research is needed to trace how women's confidence develops through success, failure and institutional change, while mixed-method and participatory action research could link statistical patterns to lived experiences and empower women to co-produce knowledge aligned with community priorities. Comparative studies across governance systems and cultural contexts, and feminist methodologies such as narrative inquiry and ethnographic approaches, would further foreground the gendered power relations shaping entrepreneurial trajectories and reveal how confidence is experienced and negotiated within patriarchal structures.

Ethics statement

With the submission of this manuscript, I would like to undertake that all authors of this research paper have directly participated in the planning, execution or analysis of this study. The contents of this manuscript are not now being considered for publication elsewhere. In addition, there are no directly related manuscripts or abstracts, published or unpublished, by any authors of this paper. This study instrument was approved by the university's Research Ethics Committee (Ref: 600-FHOTOUR (PJI 5/4))

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Appendix

Table A1. Reviewed articles (2014–2026)

No	Author(s) and year	Objectives	Methodology	Gap	Key findings
1	Abbasianchavari and Moritz (2021)	Explore how role models affect entrepreneurs	Systematic literature review	Fragmented studies, no structured overview	Role models influence intentions and behavior
2	Al Issa *et al.* (2019)	Explore ESE effect on persistence	PLS-SEM on 273 entrepreneurs	Lack of empirical studies on passion	ESE, passion, literacy affect persistence
3	Abukhalifeh and Wondirad (2019)	Examines the contributions of local stakeholder participation in community-based tourism to the socio-economic well-being of residents on Pulau Redang, Malaysia	Utilises a quantitative survey of 85 local CBT stakeholders on Pulau Redang, analysed through citizen participation frameworks	Fills a gap in island tourism literature regarding how community involvement moves beyond surface-level participation to deliver actual socio-economic benefits	Finds that effective CBT participation enhances local livelihoods but frequently encounters tokenism, requiring strong leadership and structured community organisations for true sustainable impact
4	Agumadu *et al.* (2020)	Investigates the impact of assertiveness traits on the social performance (social responsibility and responsiveness) of women SME entrepreneurs in Nigeria	Employs a quantitative survey of 520 Nigerian women SME owners, analysed using partial least squares structural equation modelling (SEM-PLS)	Bridges a research gap regarding how individual psychological traits like female assertiveness directly shape non-financial social performance outcomes in developing market SMEs	Demonstrates that women's assertiveness has a statistically significant positive effect on SME social performance, driven mainly by self-confidence in offerings and task focus
5	Ariffin *et al.* (2021)	Examine policy/ institution gaps for women entrepreneurs	Literature and policy review	Few policies address grassroots women	Weak support system; need new framework
6	Amir *et al.* (2017)	Assess CBT in Melaka UNESCO area, esp. food and beverage sector	Case study and analysis	Limited focus on specific CBT sectors	F&B sector shows CBT success; supports local economy and heritage
7	Bagus *et al.* (2019)	Explore issues and strategies in CBT	Secondary data and literature review	Limited local participation in CBT decisions	Need coordination and community empowerment
8	Klongthong *et al.* (2020)	Examine effect of ESE & innovation on Thai startup performance	Survey of startup firms, statistical analysis	Few studies link ESE & innovation to startup outcomes in Thailand	ESE & innovation positively influence firm performance

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Table A1. Continued

No	Author(s) and year	Objectives	Methodology	Gap	Key findings
9	Hamdani *et al.* (2023)	Investigate role of gender stereotypes, social support and self-efficacy in women's entrepreneurial intentions	Survey research, quantitative analysis	Limited studies integrating stereotypes, support and self-efficacy together	Positive social support and strong self-efficacy boost women's entrepreneurial intentions despite stereotypes
10	Balasingam (2022)	Study community role in homestay sustainability	Quantitative surveys with 4 stakeholder groups	Few studies link CBT to sustainability	CBT principles support homestay sustainability
11	Alzyoud *et al.* (2023)	Explore factors shaping ESE and intention	SEM analysis on 246 students	Limited studies in hospitality context	ESE mediates modelling and satisfaction effect
12	Cabrera and Mauricio (2017)	Identify factors shaping women's biz success	Literature review (2010–2015)	No organised model of success factors	Human capital, resources impact each stage
13	Moswete and Lacey (2015)	Explore women's empowerment through cultural tourism in Botswana	Qualitative study with interviews and fieldwork	Limited research on women's leadership in African tourism	Cultural tourism offers opportunities for empowerment, but gender norms still restrict leadership roles
14	Bastian *et al.* (2018)	Review MENA women's entrepreneurship research	Gender-aware narrative literature review	Lacks theory, diversity, regional focus	Fragmented studies; need diverse approaches
15	Durrah *et al.* (2024)	Identify motivation behind rural women's entrepreneurship	Survey (183 respondents), SEM using SmartPLS	Lack of Omani-based rural entrepreneurship studies	External and self-efficacy drive behaviour
16	Ali *et al.* (2024)	Explores how engaging in tourism entrepreneurship contributes to multidimensional women's empowerment within the socio-culturally conservative Hunza Valley of Pakistan	Employs a qualitative approach interviewing owners of 24 women-led tourism enterprises in the Hunza Valley	Bridges a gap in mountain tourism literature regarding the transformative potential and gender dynamics of female entrepreneurship in remote, traditional high-altitude regions	Shows that women-led tourism enterprises significantly boost financial autonomy, self-confidence and community leadership, offering a framework to drive gender equality in mountain destinations
17	Ferreira-Neto *et al.* (2023)	Examine influence of self-efficacy, passion and creativity on entrepreneurial intentions	Survey research, quantitative analysis	Limited studies combining self-efficacy, passion and creativity	Self-efficacy strongly predicts entrepreneurial intentions; passion and creativity enhance this effect
18	Filimonau *et al.* (2024)	Examine women tourism entrepreneurs in crisis	Interviews with 33 women entrepreneurs	Few tourism studies in life event crises	Social capital and habitus sustain resilience

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Table A1. Continued

No	Author(s) and year	Objectives	Methodology	Gap	Key findings
19	Fan *et al.* (2023)	Examine role of "community" in CBT	Conceptual review with case insights	Unclear, inconsistent use of "community" in CBT	Community often seen as homogeneous; need critical view for equity and sustainability
20	Garaika *et al.* (2019)	Examine how education, role models, self-efficacy, personality and confidence influence intention	Quantitative, SEM with 200 respondents	Limited integrated models for young entrepreneurs	Education and role models affect self-efficacy; ESE, personality, confidence influence intention
21	Giampiccoli *et al.* (2020)	Examine how CBT relates to sustainable tourism	Conceptual paper; literature and manual analysis	Mismatch in sustainability concepts between ST & CBT	CBT lacks explicit environmental focus; ST must lead sustainable efforts
22	Iraola-Arroyo *et al.* (2020)	Identify influential factors in developing entrepreneurship self-efficacy in students	Quantitative; 110 students surveyed in Lima, Peru	Limited studies on personal/familial predictors of self-efficacy in Peruvian context	Self-efficacy aligns with HRM and business goal-setting
23	Khalid *et al.* (2025)	Examine entrepreneurial factors and mindset influencing women's tourism initiatives and resilience	Quantitative, cluster sampling; 372 women entrepreneurs; PLS-SEM	Limited studies on women's resilience and empowerment in post-disaster tourism	Entrepreneurial factors drive initiatives; mindset mediates resilience and empowerment
24	Luekveerawattana (2024)	Investigate the factors that drive homestay tourism success, focusing on safe and relaxed atmosphere, homestay business management, and cultural and natural values	Quantitative, cluster sampling of tourists and homestay hosts, structural equation modelling	Limited integration of management, safety and cultural/natural value factors as joint drivers of homestay success in prior CBT literature	Hosts' care and safety, effectiveness of the management committee and attractiveness of local products and attractions significantly contribute to homestay success

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Table A1. Continued

No	Author(s) and year	Objectives	Methodology	Gap	Key findings
25	Madawala *et al.* (2023)	Examines how entrepreneurial self-efficacy influences performance, risk tolerance and growth strategies among female tourism entrepreneurs	Conducts a qualitative study utilising semi-structured interviews with women operating micro and small tourism businesses, analysed through thematic coding	Fills a theoretical gap regarding how psychological self-belief operates specifically within the gendered, highly volatile context of tourism entrepreneurship	Shows that elevated entrepreneurial self-efficacy is critical for overcoming socio-cultural barriers, enabling innovation and sustaining business success in tourism
26	Madawala *et al.* (2025)	Explore how entrepreneurial self-efficacy shapes resilience and reputation strategies during crises among women entrepreneurs in tourism	Qualitative study (in-depth interviews)	Limited understanding of ESE as a strategic resource in crisis contexts	ESE drives resilience, adaptive strategies and proactive reputation management
27	Makandwa *et al.* (2023)	Explore skills of rural women entrepreneurs	Qualitative, narrative-based interviews	Limited research on skill variations	Skills vary; gaps in tech, legislation, quality
28	Maheshwari and Kha (2022)	Examine ESE and TPB as mediators	Quantitative, CFA & SEM, 401 students	No study tested serial mediation model	Support impacts intention via ESE, TPB
29	Maldonado-Erazo *et al.* (2020)	Identify CBT initiatives and coverage in Ecuador	Descriptive, secondary data review	Few studies on CBT network structure	Only 18 CBT centres active; network vital
30	Malebana and Swanepoel (2014)	Explore education's effect on ESE and intent	Quantitative survey, 355 rural students	Rural context underexplored in ESE studies	Education boosts ESE; ESE predicts intent
31	Malek and Costa (2015)	Propose framework for community tourism planning	Case study	Limited integration of social innovation in CBT	Community input improves tourism, needs collaboration

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Table A1. Continued

No	Author(s) and year	Objectives	Methodology	Gap	Key findings
32	Altinay *et al.* (2026)	Investigates how women tourism entrepreneurs act as cultural custodians by balancing heritage preservation with business goals through the lens of social feminism theory	Employs a qualitative exploratory approach using 26 semi-structured interviews with women heritage-tourism entrepreneurs in Cyprus, analysed via thematic analysis	Addresses the literature's overemphasis on economic metrics by revealing how women integrate non-financial, cultural stewardship into male-dominated business models	Reveals that women leverage cultural identity, integrated practices, social advocacy, community collaboration and resilience to transform traditional gender constraints into cultural preservation
33	Martini *et al.* (2020)	Analyse women's role in rural tourism	Exploratory, 11 interviews with women entrepreneurs	Female tourism roles in rural areas underexplored	Women innovate, manage and network in CBT
34	Msimango-Galawe and Mazonde (2024)	Investigate the mediating effect of entrepreneurial self-efficacy on the relationship between business experience and performance of women-owned enterprise	Quantitative, random sampling, online questionnaire, 258 women entrepreneurs, hierarchical regression and mediation analysis	Limited understanding of which specific ESE dimension mediates the business-experience-to-performance relationship for women-owned enterprises	Industry experience was the strongest predictor of business performance, partially mediated by the innovation dimension of ESE specifically; the management dimension of ESE showed predictive power but no significant mediating effect
35	Na-Allah and Ahmad (2022)	Examine SELF & ENTSUP in venture creation	Quantitative, PLS-SEM, 291 graduates	Limited studies on SELF & ENTSUP roles	SELF mediates VC; ENTSUP moderates negatively
36	Najib *et al.* (2020)	Link innovation, ESE, uniqueness to performance	SEM, 124 restaurant respondents	Few studies link ESE to marketing performance	Innovation & ESE improve performance; uniqueness doesn't
37	Narkunienė and Ulbinaitė (2018)	Compare financial and non-financial evaluation methods	Systematic analysis and comparison	Lack of unified evaluation method for firms	Modern methods must combine both indicators
38	Neneh (2022)	Explore ESE and social support as mediators	Moderated mediation, 500 university students	Limited studies on moderated mediation in passion–intention	ESE mediates; social support moderates effect
39	Ngoasong and Kimbu (2019)	Examine growth paths in resource-scarce contexts	Qualitative, 16 case studies	Growth constraints in embedded female entrepreneurship	Embeddedness aids access but limits growth

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Table A1. Continued

No	Author(s) and year	Objectives	Methodology	Gap	Key findings
40	Nikmah *et al.* (2023)	Explore institutional support's impact on ESE	Quantitative, 235 MSME respondents	Few studies on institutional role in ESE	Support boosts ESE, drives economy, empowers women
41	Noor and Isa (2020)	Identify growth and failure factors in Pakistan	Qualitative, interviews with 25 women	Limited insights on Pakistani women's business struggles	Policies, low confidence, awareness hinder success
42	Noreña-Chavez and Guevara (2020)	Analyse passion's mediation on ESE–innovation link	PLS-SEM, 358 company participants	Few studies link ESE and innovation behaviour	Passion mediates ESE's effect on innovation
43	Nziku and Henry (2021)	Critique policies for women's entrepreneurship	Document analysis using reading guide	Policies lack gender/context sensitivity in Tanzania	Policies must be localised, gender-focused
44	Parte and Alberca (2021)	Compare efficiency in rural vs cultural tourism	DEA, non-parametric modelling, firm microdata	Limited comparison of tourism business performance	Rural firms more efficient; size/location matter
45	Pelegrini and Moraes (2022)	Examine gender, ESE and ecosystem influence	PLS-SEM, 467 university students	Limited gender-specific studies in ecosystems	Ecosystem boosts ESE; females show stronger impact
46	Priatmoko *et al.* (2021)	Explore villagers' view on sustainable CBT	Triangulation: interviews, observation, sustainability data	Lack of local perspective in rural CBT	Leadership drives CBT; not just community solidarity
47	Rao *et al.* (2022)	Examine rural women's competence improvement	Case study of 10-year program	Limited focus on learning in rural tourism	Action learning boosts skills and independence
48	Rosca *et al.* (2020)	Compare social entrepreneurship in emerging markets	Multiple case study	Gendered view in social entrepreneurship underexplored	Women switch logic types; driven by social issues
49	Shahab *et al.* (2019)	Test ESE-EI model with creativity and education	SEM, survey of 808 students	Few studies on moderated mediation across markets	EC and ATE mediate; EE strengthens the effect
50	Shahzad *et al.* (2021)	Examine factors influencing start-up intention	Survey, 416 business students	Lack of path model linking key motivators	Skills, risk, innovativeness mediate EI drivers
51	Shastri *et al.* (2019)	Explore motivations and challenges of women entrepreneurs	Qualitative, 13 in-depth interviews	Few studies on institutional views in Rajasthan	Informal support drives ESE; gender roles hinder

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Table A1. Continued

No	Author(s) and year	Objectives	Methodology	Gap	Key findings
52	Xiaoning *et al.* (2026)	Examine women's empowerment and participation in sustainable CBT development	Quantitative, 341 women in China; PLS-SEM	Limited evidence linking empowerment, perceived impacts and CBT participation	Women's empowerment shapes impact perceptions and enhances participation in sustainable tourism
53	Yousafzai and Aljanova (2025)	Examine feminist solidarity and collective empowerment in CBT entrepreneurship	Qualitative, 32 interviews; post-colonial feminist analysis	Limited understanding of collective empowerment in CBT contexts	Feminist solidarity drives empowerment, collective action and socio-economic transformation

Source(s): Researcher tabulation

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